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A FOUR-MONTH HONEYMOON

The three-Test series in March 1998 was the first fully fledged home series against Australia of my career. It generated a lot of hype and much of it was being built up as a contest between myself and Shane Warne. It's inevitable that there are times when battles between two individuals hog most of the limelight. For example, Brian Lara versus Glenn McGrath, Ricky Ponting versus Courtney Walsh, or even Tendulkar versus Lara, as had been the case in 1994. I always said that this series was a contest between two teams and not two individuals, though in my heart of hearts I knew it was a very important match-up against Warne. Shane was bowling beautifully and had just had a great series against South Africa in Australia, taking twenty wickets in three Tests.

Knowing that I would soon be facing him, I studied Warne's bowling in that series carefully. It appeared to me that his biggest strength was the drift he managed to get, which meant that the batsman was somewhat blinded by the delivery if he was batting with a traditional side-on stance. Because of the extra drift, the ball would tend to go away from the vision of the batsman and it became that much more difficult to negotiate the extra spin. As a result, I decided to open up my stance a little to Warne and to stand slightly outside the leg stump. I also planned to play him more from the crease and as late as possible. I hardly stepped out to him all series and, more often than not, kept hitting him towards midwicket with a horizontal bat whenever he tried to extract extra spin from leg stump or slightly outside. By playing from the crease and by using the horizontal bat, I reckoned I had opened up the option of punishing him if he bowled short and could also play the cut shot on the